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MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM MGU-UGP (HONOURS) REGULAR EXAMINATION March 2026
Fourth SEMESTER Discipline Specific Elective (DSE) - MG4DSEHIS200 – WORLD HISTORY FROM EARLY MEDIEVAL TO EARLY MODERN PERIOD (2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS) Duration: 2 hours Maximum Marks: 70

Part A
Multiple Choice Questions
Answer any 10 questions
Each question carries 1 marks

1. b). Strengthening of urban centres

2. d). State consolidation and empire building

3. b). Institutes of the Christian Religion

4. b). Rational and empirical inquiry

5. b). Rural, religious, and community-oriented

6. c). Political fragmentation and clan-based loyalty

7. c). Growth of anatomical knowledge

8. b). Sponsorship of maritime exploration

9. c). Foundations for urban and commercial growth

10. d). Divine law interpreted by scholars

11. a). Provided religious and symbolic legitimacy

12. a). Alliance with the church and appointment of bishops

Part B
Short Answer Questions
Answer any 5 questions
Each question carries 2 marks

13. Pope Leo IX (pontificate: 1049–1054) - reforming pope of the medieval Church - played a key role in the Gregorian Reform movement, aiming to eliminate corruption such as simony and clerical marriage, and to strengthen papal authority over the Church - the Great Schism of 1054, which resulted in the division between the Roman Catholic and Eastern Orthodox Churches.

14. An official in medieval Islamic administration responsible for supervising public morals and market regulations - ensured fair trade practices, checked weights and measures, prevented fraud, and upheld Islamic ethical standards in public life - part of the system known as Hisba, which aimed at maintaining social justice and order in accordance with Islamic law.

15. The Great Schism of 1378 - a major crisis in the Catholic Church when rival popes claimed authority at the same time - In 1378, after the election of Pope Urban VI in Rome, a group of cardinals opposed him and elected another pope, Pope Clement VII, who established his court at Avignon. This led to a division in Christendom, with different European kingdoms supporting different popes - The schism weakened the authority of the papacy and continued until 1417 - resolved by the Council of Constance, which restored unity under a single pope.

16. An ancient astronomical theory which holds that the Earth is at the center of the universe, and all celestial bodies—such as the Sun, Moon, planets, and stars—revolve around it - most systematically developed by Claudius Ptolemy in the 2nd century CE and remained dominant in medieval European and Islamic thought until it was challenged by the heliocentric model proposed by Nicolaus Copernicus.

17. Marc Bloch defined European feudalism as a complex system of social, economic, and political relationships rather than merely a legal or military arrangement-Fragmentation of political authority-a system of personal bonds of loyalty-the granting of fiefs-a manorial economy-mutual obligations and hierarchy-a network of interdependent relationships rooted in land, power, and social obligations.

18. The first hereditary Islamic dynasty-ruling from 661 to 750 CE with its capital at Damascus - founded by Muawiya I- marked the transformation of the caliphate into a dynastic empire - with Arabic as the official language, they developed a strong military and bureaucratic system - their rule faced opposition, especially from groups who opposed hereditary succession, leading to their overthrow by the Abbasids in 750 CE.

19. Protestantism - a reform movement that began in the early 16th century, initiated by Martin Luther in 1517 - protested against abuses in the Catholic Church such as indulgences and corruption - emphasized faith alone (justification by faith), the authority of the Bible, and rejected papal supremacy.

Counter-Reformation (Catholic Reformation) - the response of the Catholic Church to the spread of Protestantism during the 16th century - Guided by institutions like the Council of Trent - aimed to reform internal abuses and reassert Catholic doctrines - strengthened the authority of the Pope and revitalized the Church through new religious orders like the Jesuits.

20. The Glorious Revolution refers to the events of 1688 in England when King James II was overthrown and replaced by William III and Mary II - it is called “glorious” because it involved relatively little bloodshed in England - established the supremacy of Parliament over the monarchy and led to the constitutional monarchy, confirmed by the Bill of Rights (1689) - marked a decisive step in limiting royal power and strengthening parliamentary democracy in England.

Part C
Short Essay Questions
Answer any 4 questions
Each question carries 5 marks

21. According to Marc Bloch in Feudal Society, feudalism was an integrated system where social, economic, and political elements were inseparable. Political power was decentralized and exercised through personal bonds of lordship and vassalage, rather than centralized institutions. The economic foundation lay in the manorial system, where land controlled production and sustained both lords and dependents. Social hierarchy was based on mutual obligations and dependency, linking all classes from kings to peasants. Thus, feudalism functioned as a network of interdependent relationships rooted in land, power, and social structure.

22. The Scientific Revolution marked a shift from reliance on tradition and authority to knowledge based on observation and experimentation. Thinkers like Francis Bacon emphasized the experimental method, arguing that scientific truths must be derived from systematic observation and repeated testing. Experimentation allowed scientists to verify hypotheses, challenge long-held beliefs, and establish universal laws of nature. Figures such as Galileo Galilei used experiments to support new ideas about motion and astronomy, helping to replace older

theories like the geocentric model. Thus, experimentation became the foundation of modern science, ensuring accuracy, objectivity, and continuous advancement of knowledge.

23. The major developments in Renaissance art in Europe can be summarised as follows - Humanism in art - Decline of purely religious purpose - Rise of individual artists - Realism and study of nature - Use of scientific techniques - Advances in painting, sculpture, and architecture - Secular outlook in art and architecture

24. Mercantilism was closely linked to the rise of nation-states - promoted strong centralized governments that could regulate trade, impose tariffs, and control economic activity - wealth generated through trade and colonies enabled rulers to finance armies and administrative systems, strengthening state power - mercantilist policies encouraged colonial expansion and national competition, reinforcing political unity and identity - mercantilism provided the economic foundation for the growth of modern nation-states.

25. Christianity in early medieval Europe functioned not only as a religion but also as a powerful social institution - it provided a unified belief system, moral code, and spiritual authority under the leadership of the Catholic Church - Socially, the Church played a central role in education, charity, and welfare, running monasteries, schools, and hospitals - influenced political life, legitimizing rulers and shaping laws and social norms - helped create a sense of cultural unity across fragmented feudal societies, making it a key integrating force in early medieval Europe.

26. Early Islamic societies made remarkable contributions to science by preserving, synthesizing, and advancing knowledge from Greek, Persian, and Indian traditions. In medicine, scholars like Ibn Sina produced works such as the Canon of Medicine, systematizing medical knowledge and emphasizing clinical observation and hospitals. In mathematics, figures such as Al-Khwarizmi developed algebra and introduced the decimal numeral system, greatly influencing later European mathematics. In astronomy, scholars improved observational techniques, built observatories, and refined planetary models, contributing to more accurate calendars and navigation. Overall, early Islamic societies played a crucial role in the development and transmission of scientific knowledge, shaping the foundations of later European advancements.

27. The Sassanid Empire grounded its political authority in religious legitimacy, closely aligning the monarchy with Zoroastrianism. The king was regarded as divinely sanctioned, and the powerful priestly class reinforced royal authority by controlling ritual, law, and ideology. This alliance helped create a centralized and hierarchical state, where religion justified social stratification into distinct classes such as priests, warriors, and peasants. At the same time, religion functioned as an instrument of social regulation, shaping laws, moral conduct, and community identity. However, this close fusion of religion and state also had limitations: it restricted religious pluralism and sometimes led to the persecution of groups like Christians and Manichaeans, creating internal tensions. Moreover, the dominance of the priesthood could challenge royal authority, revealing a complex and sometimes contested relationship between kings and clergy. Thus, religion in the Sassanid Empire was both a source of political legitimacy and social cohesion, but also a factor that could produce rigidity and conflict within the imperial structure.

Part D
Essay Questions
Answer any 2 questions
Each question carries 15 marks

28. The statement challenges the older view that medieval towns were primarily forces of anti-feudal change. In fact, towns largely emerged within the framework of feudal society, often under the protection and authority of feudal lords who granted charters and privileges to encourage

trade and revenue. Economically, they grew out of the agrarian surplus and local exchange networks of the feudal system, rather than standing outside it. At the same time, towns did introduce new elements—such as merchant activity, guild organization, and monetary exchange—which gradually modified feudal relations. However, these changes were slow and uneven, and many towns remained closely tied to feudal obligations and hierarchies. Thus, medieval towns were initially products and extensions of feudal society, though over time they contributed to its transformation rather than its immediate destruction.

29. Prophet Muhammad laid the foundations of a stable Islamic state through a combination of religious leadership, political organization, and social reform. The Hijra (622 CE) to Medina marked the transition from a persecuted community to a political entity, where the Constitution of Medina established a pluralistic order integrating Muslims, Jews, and other groups under a common framework of governance. He unified diverse tribal groups by replacing kinship loyalties with a broader community (ummah) based on faith and mutual obligation. Administratively, he introduced systems of taxation (zakat), dispute resolution, and leadership that ensured social justice and cohesion. Military organization and strategic diplomacy enabled the consolidation of authority across Arabia, culminating in the peaceful conquest of Mecca. However, while these measures created a strong and unified polity, the absence of a clearly defined succession mechanism after his death in 632 CE revealed underlying vulnerabilities. Thus, the Prophet successfully established the institutional and ideological foundations of an Islamic state, though its long-term stability depended on subsequent political developments.

30. The Crusades were a series of military campaigns launched by Western European Christians between the 11th and 13th centuries to recover the Holy Land from Muslim control. The First Crusade (1096–1099) was the most successful, resulting in the capture of Jerusalem and the establishment of Crusader states. The Second Crusade (1147–1149) failed to regain lost territories, while the Third Crusade (1189–1192), led by rulers like Richard I of England and Saladin, ended in a compromise allowing Christian access to holy sites. Later Crusades, including the Fourth Crusade (1202–1204), deviated from their original purpose, notably leading to the sack of Constantinople. The consequences were far-reaching: they intensified religious hostility between Christians and Muslims, weakened the Byzantine Empire, and failed to achieve lasting control of the Holy Land. At the same time, they stimulated trade and cultural exchanges between East and West, contributed to the decline of feudalism, and strengthened monarchies in Europe.

31. The emergence of the European state system, had profound long-term political consequences. It established the principle of sovereign territorial states, replacing the fragmented authority of feudal and universal institutions like the Papacy and the Holy Roman Empire. This led to the consolidation of centralized political authority, enabling the growth of bureaucracies, standing armies, and more efficient governance. At the same time, the system encouraged interstate competition and balance-of-power politics, which, while preventing universal domination, also contributed to frequent wars and rivalries. It laid the foundation for modern international relations, where states became the primary actors guided by diplomacy and strategic interests. However, the emphasis on sovereignty often limited supranational cooperation and justified imperial expansion and colonial domination. Thus, the European state system created a stable framework for political organization, but one that was also marked by conflict, competition, and global inequalities.